

Price Watch

We scout the market for smartphones under 15k, phablets and tablets for all your portable requirements

Killer Rigs

On a budget? Want to build a compact HTPC? Here's our list of perfect components to assemble your own PC



Welcome to the world of high-fidelity portable audio

Agent 001 helps you pick the right in-ear headphones for your needs

In-ear monitors, more commonly known as in-ear headphones or canalphones, are a budding Audiophile's gateway to the world of high-fidelity audio. The reason is that unlike speakers or proper circumaural headphones, IEMs give you access to high quality audio at a fraction of the cost. To get the same kind of quality on a set of speakers or headphones you'd have to spend a bomb. In-ears are also infinitely more portable and make for perfect companions on those long boring daily commutes – because of their inherent design, they passively block out a lot of ambient noise. The only trouble with in-ears, if at all, is that they take getting used to, and finding a perfect fit is a bit difficult. Thankfully most manufacturers include a set of tips in different sizes to fit most ears. This brings us to the most important question: how do you choose the right one for you?

The in-ear market is quite diverse, with options starting from the humble Creative EP-630 (which is surprisingly still going strong on sites like Flipkart at a price of ₹799) to the precision high-end pieces like the Sennheiser IE80 (₹24,990) or UltimateEars UE 900 (₹34,995). And these are just the high-end retail options. Once you go into the custom moulded space, the sky's the limit. Even the brands in the space are far too many to keep track of. So for the sake of simplicity let's

break it down into a couple of sound signature preferences.

For the bass lovers

In-ears usually are skewed towards bass performance. The bass also greatly depends on how snug the fit is. One of the most bass heavy in-ears to grace the Digit Test Center was the JBL J22i. It's a bass-head's delight and for the asking price of ₹2,990 they're not bad at all. If you don't want outlandish bass performance and are looking for something heavy but at the same time, taut, the Klipsch Image S4i is a worthy though slightly expensive option at a price of ₹5499. If your purse strings are a little tight this month the Tekfusion - Twinwoofers (₹1,399) are a good option. Made by an Indian company, they were far better than we expected.

Neutral

For a long time the Meelectronics M6 was a reference set at the Digit test center. It still remains a decent flat sound-signature piece for a humble sub-2k price. Trouble is, they're a little difficult to procure. Another all round good performer is the Cowon EM1. At a price of ₹750 (for the non-microphone version) these are easily one of the best performing in-ears for the price. In fact they could easily be the next EP-630. The microphone version costs

a little more (Rs. 1,099) but is worth the price for the tangle free cable and build quality. If money is not an issue look no further than the MartinLogan Mikros 70. It is handsdown the most neutral and precise IEM we've heard in a long time. But be prepared to shell out ₹9,900 (where to buy: <http://dgit.in/16oyOrH>).

General tips

While buying in-ears read as many reviews as you can but stay away from the general hype that populates forums. Take the case of the old EP 630. Sure *for the price they were* good, but the hype from a few years ago made them out to be god's greatest gift to human ears! That's the thing with internet hype; every now and then people get caught up with a trend. The XBA 3 was one such piece that didn't live up to the hype. Also remember that manufacturers usually give away review units to self-proclaimed audiophile forum reviewers, who are overcome with gratitude with the chance to keep the review units for "long term testing". These days there is a lot of talk about the Signature Acoustics C-12 Elements wooden IEMs. Digit got a review unit and again, the hype proved disproportionate. Last protip: buying earphones is easiest from online sources such as eBay, Flipkart, etc. 